

Anarchy in 2013

Another year, another iPad / iPhone / Android release / new OS / 1000 new smartphone models / a million app updates... is that really all that we can look forward to? There's the hype that surrounds almost everything that's being touted as path-breaking, earth-shattering, all-new, etc. Excuse me while I yawn my head off... and not just because it's 8 AM (which is midnight for me), but out of genuine boredom.

Don't get me wrong, I'm not blaming the millions who work in the IT industry for wasting their time, passing off half-baked products as must-have treats. No, on the contrary, I'm blaming us, the consumers. Companies will make what we buy, just as people will Like on Facebook what everyone else Likes. There's a herd mentality at play, and it has a significant role in making or breaking aforementioned companies. Can you really blame them for jumping on bandwagons?

It's really a risk vs. gain balance sheet for most people and companies. Why risk everything when there are profits to be made? However, thankfully, our herd mentality also brings about monopolies by companies. Yes, you read that correctly, I did say and mean thankfully.

Wintel (Windows+Intel) has ruled the PC segment for a decade, RIM ruled the smartphone market and Nokia ruled the overall phone market, the tablet market now is controlled by a weird coalition of Apple, Samsung and Google... all monopolies of sorts.

The one thing monopolies and dictatorships have in common is that there's always anarchy at some point, and monopolies, like dictatorships, eventually crumble. When this does happen, we see a growth spurt, and in technology terms, we see innovation. That's why I'm thankful.

If Apple, Microsoft and Linux all had near equal shares in the desktop market, would Apple have been able to (or even had the will to) divert enough effort away from desktops to make the iPod / iPhone / iPad? Monopolies force people to innovate, not just with the products at hand, but also sometimes (as Apple did) force them to create an all new product category, and divert our focus away from existing (and monopolised) categories. And they did just that with touch-based devices, despite never really "creating" the technologies or even the basic ideas.

Portable MP3 players had existed for years before the iPod, touch-based input methods years before the iPhone/iPod Touch, and tablets way before the iPad... they were just not implemented

as well by other companies, who were too busy raking in the moolah on desktops and laptops to bother innovating into a new device category.

That's what monopolies do, force currently less relevant companies to innovate, to change the game, re-invent themselves – much like the struggling Nintendo did with the Wii. Can you imagine gaming on a console these days without some form of motion control?

Interestingly, the companies struggling to stay relevant today are not unknown, come-from-nowhere, Mark Zuckerberg types; they're behemoths such as Nokia, Intel, Microsoft, RIM, etc. For me, my real hope for 2013 is that these companies look beyond balance sheets and realise that they are almost playing the role of start-ups in certain vital segments of technology, and innovation is the only way out.

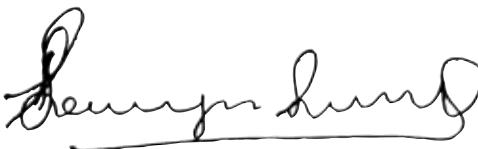
The very first sign of this happening is the spreading of OSes from one platform to another. Just as Linux went from personal PCs and servers and to phones, Windows for the first time properly migrates from PC to phone and tablet, Android's being sneaky and trying to get into the desktop, Chrome and Firefox have offerings... It's an all-out war, and thus had to be our first cover story of the year. You will read more in the pages that follow.

Over the year we will look at more such trends, and look to bring you even more insights into the cutting edge of technology that you will see sometime in the future. Of course we will continue to give you your regular dose of the latest in hardware, gadgets and gizmos, but we will also make sure to help you navigate the exciting but choppy waters that lie ahead.

Although many updates to existing products lie ahead, I'm more excited by the unknown than the latest iPad. Will we soon wear personal area network sensors, see a new human-computer interaction method (brain control anyone?), get smarter gadgets (with the beginnings of AI perhaps?), 3D print parts we need?

I don't know a definitive answer to the question, "What will 2013 be the year of in technology?", which is why I asked Team Digit to write about it this month.

Happy new year everyone, and let's hope 2013 is a great year for innovation. 



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